Attack of the Moral Fuzzies

By Nancy Beverly

AT RISE: *Somber Voice (In Darkness):* Do you feel lost? Indecisive? Queasy? Are you a stumbler in the dark? Flailing your arms hopelessly, hitting your head against unseen walls? Are you tossing and turning on the stormy sea of life, miles from a harbor of safety and calm? *(pause)* Relax, Beth. Come with us. No more indecision. No more guilt. Life made simple. Join us as we play the dream of your choice, MORALITY MADE EASY!!!

INTRODUCTION

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And now, here's your host, Ramon!

(Zippy music, bright lights – blinking lights if available – as RAMON, our sleazy host, sweeps in. His able-bodied assistant, MISS LOWENTHAL, runs around throwing confetti, balloons, the whole number. Note: RAMON is not necessarily of Spanish descent; accent is optional.)

RAMON: Good evening, good morning, good grief, good God, great gosh almighty, hot diggity dog, come on in, sit right down, we're here, you're there, and our contestant, BethAnn Shumway is *on the spot!* *(BethAnn Shumway enters or lights rise to reveal her. She has put on her nice Sunday outfit to come down here. She smiles nervously. She simultaneously wants to be here and wants not to mess up.)* Say Hi, BethAnn!

BETHANN: Are we on?

RAMON: We're always on, dear, that's one of the problems. Life just won't let up, will it? But today we're going to take away all of that trauma. Won't that be wonderful?

BETHANN: Yes, it will, Ramon.

RAMON: Now about those rules: millions and zillions of 'em, entirely to complicated to understand. If we understood the Rules of Life, we wouldn't have to play the game. Ah, the Game, the Game, she is simple. Five fun-filled rounds, each more pleasant than the last, each hinging on you unhinging that conscience. And after each one, we hook you up to the old Anxiety-o-meter to see how you're doing. Yes, how fast can you get to Nirvana, or as we like to call it, Okey-Dokey Land. Just to see where we are, let's take that first preliminary reading. Miss Lowenthal, if you would do the honors. *(MISS L has already gotten the meter, or effortlessly escorts BETHANN to a contraption. RAMON does a trumpet fanfare.)* Doooo doo doo doo doo doo doooooooooo…a nine and a half! *(SFX: taped groans)* BethAnn, for heaven's sake, come away from that thing. What in the world is causing all that trauma? *(stage whisper)* This is the part where you tell us about yourself.

BETHANN: Oh. Well, I work in a hospital in a cancer ward where I counsel families of dying patients.

MISS L: God, that must be terrible. How do you get through it all?

BETH: I don't. Some days I just stay in bed and cry all da-

RAMON: Well, BethAnn, it's time to get rolling, time for Round One: *(SFX: ding)* International Follies. Ready? You're buying a new car. Do you purchase Japanese because it has a better performance record… *(Lights up on a poster of a Japanese car)* or American, to support the home auto industry? *(Another car poster. Thkinking music. SFX: ding).*

BETH: Japanese?

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RAMON: Okay, Miss Lowenthal, let's see who you've got there! *(Miss L pulls a curtain or lights reveal DAVE).* Dave Armstrong!

DAVE: *(eager, freshly scrubbed face)* Thank you, BethAnn for helping support my dad's Toyota dealership. Because of people like you, both Japanese and American workers can stay employed – like my dad and me and my brother Dwayne – and also you've helped keep free enterprise alive. Thank you very much, BethAnn. *(He exits or lights go out on him. MISS L leads applause.)*

MISS L: Very good, BethAnn…

RAMON: How does it feel to have made the right choice?

BETH: I, I…feel pretty good.

RAMON: Ladies and gentlemen, she feels pretty good; how good is pretty good? Let's check that out scientifically with Mr. Meter. A seven and a half, very nice, BethAnn. I think she's on a roll, so let's go to the Second Round right now. *(SFX: ding)* Funding Mania. It's time to divvy up the tax pie. There's only enough money for keeping either Basic Grants to college students… *(ELAINE appears)* or providing Day Care to working, lower-income moms. *(JOLLEEN appears.)* Which do you choose? *(Thinking music. SFX: ding).*

BETH: I guess I'd provide the Day Care.

RAMON: Okay, Miss Lowenthal, who have we got this time? *(Lights brighten on JOLLEEN.)* Jolleen Budge!

JOLLEEN: *(a little stiff and camera-shy)* Thank you, BethAnn, for thinking of us. Because of your thoughtfulness, I am able to keep working at the Tastee-Freeze and still keep Wanda Sue at the Day Care Center where she receives excellent looking-after, and then I still have enough money left over to buy new tires this year. Thank you, BethAnn. *(BETH has noticed ELAINE exiting, but MISS L and RAMON have maneuvered her attention to matters at hand. Applause.)*

MISS L: Aww, I feel so warm and wonderful. How about you, BethAnn?

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BETH: I, I feel terrific. *(shaking the tension out of her hands)* Boy oh boy, this is so nice. You know, I used to have this little knot right back here *(points to her shoulder blades),* but it's disappeared!

RAMON: And what's the ol' Meter telling us now?

MISS L: It's a good one. Five and a half. She's heading straight for Okey-Dokey Land.

RAMON: Jolleen's happy, Dave's happy, I'm happy, you're happy, BethAnn's happy, the guys in the booth are happy, the parking lot attendant's happy, one big happy family! Round Three – *(During RAMON's digression BETH's eyes have strayed back to where ELAINE exited.)*

BETH: Uh, Ramon, could I ask one quick question? . . . I was just wondering…does that girl get to go to college, now that she doesn't have a Basic Grant?

RAMON: I believe you're straying from our guidelines, dear.

MISS L: No worrying allowed.

BETH: I'm not worrying…exactly. I was just curious. Could I just, you know, chat for a second? It'll only take a second. Where is she, back here?

RAMON: *(Sings, under his breath)* "Every party has a pooper… *(MISS L joins him)* …that's why we invited her, party pooper…" *(BETH enters dragging ELAINE, who is quite confused.)*

ELAINE: What's going on?

RAMON: Oh, not much. Welcome to *my* nightmare! We're making it up as we go along – BethAnn Shumway, meet Elaine Henselmeier. *(MISS L half-heartedly tosses a bit of confetti.)*

BETH: Hi, I was just wondering, do you get to go to college now?

ELAINE: I've already been – for a couple of years, in business. But I could only go part-time because I had to work. At that rate, it was taking me eight years, so I quit and got a full-time job as a receptionist in a doctor's office.

BETH: Are you going back someday?

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ELAINE: I doubt it. This job's okay –

BETH: – But this isn't fair –

ELAINE: Yeah, but I'm engaged, and my finance's got a good job selling aluminum siding

BETH: I'll give you the grant, you can have the grant – Ramon, I really don't think I'm cut out for this.

RAMON: Beth, you're thinking too much. The name of the game is Morality Made Easy, not Life's A Bitch.

RAMON: *(BETH takes a deep breath and mouths an "okay.")* Round Three. *(SFX: ding.)* Hospital Hijinx. At a famous hospital, the writing is on the wall. Funding is being cut back. Out of these three hot ticket items, which one would you support: heart transplants for adults, liver transplants for cute kids under the age of six, or medicare supplements to keep pace with the cost of living. *(Music starts, then slows down as if the electricity has been pulled. BETH quavers, knees buckle.)*

BETH: I can't do it Ramon, it's too close to home. I think I'd better just throw in the towel.

RAMON: QUITTER. *(BETH shrinks.)* You know what happens to people like you, don't you? Huh? HUH? *(BETH, feeling like five-year-old, shakes her head no.)* You become a misshapen, spineless idiot incapable of even the most elementary decisions. Miss Lowenthal! *(MISS L reveals a hunched-over male, a la the Elephant Man, with normal, albeit whiney, speech and indecisive clothing.)*

IDIOT: *(As if by rote)* I am a misshapen, spineless idiot, incapable of even the most elementary decisions.

RAMON: This is a man paralyzed by caring too much. He could once decide which countries should have the bomb, whether we should be backing the Nicaraguan Contras, and even who could or could not have an abortion. Now he can't even pick out the color of his socks in the morning. . . So you see, you have to

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choose, it's a given. *(He gestures for Miss L. to gently remove the IDIOT from out of his direct eyesight.)* Recapping Round Three: heart transplants, liver transplants, or medicare supplements. *(Fast music, SFX: ding.)*

BETH: *(in one breath)* I want the largest chunk for the medicare patients, they've paid into the system the longest, and I want the second largest chunk for kids' liver transplants because it's not their fault they were born with a bad liver, and I also want money to go for heart transplants because they seem to be having a lot of success with that recently.

RAMON: (*pause, eyes her*) Covered those bases, huh, kid? Okay, Miss Lowenthal, let 'er rip. *(BENNIE KINCAID is revealed, He's sweaty, greasy, nervous, and desperate. He's also an auto mechanic.)* Meet Bennie Kincaid!

BENNIE: BethAnn, how could you do this? The hospital bills are gonna kill us. Dad had insurance, but when they found out he had Hodgkin's disease, well, they aren't so friendly anymore. And he's only sixty-five, so this could drag on for a long time. I'm tryin' to run the Shell Station by myself, and when Dad comes home from the hospital, who's gonna take care of him 'cause Mom's gotta work? We just aren't quite keepin' up with the cost of livin', BethAnn. The increase wasn't enough.

RAMON: Meet Nada Ivanhoe! *(NADA is the warm, nurturing type. She too, is angry, but cooler about it. She speaks in modulated tones – with a veneer.)*

NADA: Hello, BethAnn. How are *you*? Have you had a nice day today? Have you enjoyed the bountiful spring weather we've been having? I don't mind telling you we're having a hard time enjoying it at the Ivanhoe home. In fact, we're not even at home most of the time. We're at the hospital with little Justin. The closest we get to spring is looking out of his hospital window. As you may know, Justin is awaiting a liver transplant. If he does not receive a new liver in the next two weeks…*(she trails off)* Well, we too, like Mr. Kincaid, are a little

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strapped for cash. The hospital was hoping to provide six free transplants this year. As you may know, funding didn't quite come through. *(pause)* But we're still praying. *(pause)* I think I hear some chickadees outside. How lovely. *(pause)* Have a nice day, BethAnn.

RAMON: And finally, Clairice White!

CLAIRICE: BethAnn, unlike Bennie and Nada, I am speaking for myself. I am dying. They just found out I have terminal heart disease. I am only twenty-three years old. I used to raise flowers for the 4-H. I used to be a cheerleader. I used to work as a dental hygienist. No more. Research on heart disease like mine needs to be done *(A TV ad:)* Only *you* can help. Give to the heart foundation of your choice. A young heart is a terrible thing to waste. Goodbye, BethAnn.

BETH: I quit, I quit, I quit, I quit, I quit, I quit… No, I *want* to make the right decision – But I keep messing up –

RAMON: So. Beth. What's up?

BETH: I messed up Round Three. I didn't make the right choice, did I?

RAMON: Are you kidding? You waffled, you fudged, you hedged, you wanted to please everyone. You and Congress. , , , Well, BethAnn Shumway, looks like the game is over.

BETH: But, but, but… Prizes, what about prizes? You kept promising prizes!

RAMON: You're too tense for prizes.

BETH: *(desperate)* Well, how about…*consolation* prizes, like a car, or a stereo, or –

RAMON: Whoa, whoa, no, no, Beth, sweetheart. There is no consolation here. We were offering peace of mind. We were offering the smug satisfaction that you'd made a good decision without second thoughts. And *you* turned it down. Prizes? If you're lucky, you'll get out of the studio in one piece – that'll be *your* prize.

BETH: *(with grim determination)* My favorite color is yellow, my favorite cereal is Raisin Bran, I am buying Japanese this time, and the money goes to Medicare.

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(Pause - She lashes out at them – and herself.) What did we all want, huh? Warm breezes and iced tea? Easy answers? People should not come on this show – I hope it dies in the ratings. *(She storms out quickly.)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2001 National Qualifier- HI
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